Device Orientation

In short

Not everyone can turn their screen, such as a wheelchair user with a tablet fixed in place. Websites and apps should work whether the screen is tall or wide, so never lock it in one direction.

What is it for?

Think about how you hold your phone. Sometimes you hold it tall (portrait) to read, and sometimes you turn it sideways (landscape) to watch a video.

For some people, turning their device is not an option. A person who uses a power wheelchair might have their tablet bolted to the armrest so it won't drop. If a website forces the screen to be tall, but their tablet is locked sideways, they can't use it. It's like bolting a TV sideways on your wall and being told to just tilt your head to watch it.

How to support it

Websites and apps should work no matter how the screen is turned.

Never use code that forces the screen to stay in just one direction.

Build designs that stretch or stack neatly to fit the screen, whether it is tall or wide.

Useful links

- World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) - Understanding Orientation
- A11y Tip: Device Orientation

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

TV: Television

W3C: World Wide Web Consortium